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**Crisis Management in Schools (CMiS)
A Model for Supportive Intervention
in Schools Following Crises /
Disastrous Events**

Developed by the European School Psychology
Centre for Training

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Introduction – the importance of crisis management in schools

Children spend a large amount of time in schools. Schools not only establish the competencies for learning and professional skills, they are a setting for establishing interpersonal relationships and transferable skills and are a unique resource to promote the healthy development of children.

Schools can provide a safe and supportive environment for children and school staff, and build protective factors such as coping skills and resilience. Effective programs in the management of schools that incorporate a holistic approach involving children, teachers and families, can reduce risk factors for poor mental health, bullying, violence and exclusions. They can help to create a social and friendly climate in classrooms.

Although they are rare, critical events occur in the school context and can heavily threaten the mental health of all members of the school community. Sound and well planned reactions by the responsible headmasters and teachers can reduce the risk of long lasting disorders. Critical incidents include accidents, natural disasters, shootings, suicides, death of a friend or family member, threats, sexual abuse, and acts of severe violence. Schools need to be prepared for supporting people affected by these events and be able to help them to return to their daily routines as quickly as possible.

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After big crises schools can fulfil their tasks better when they receive both medical and psycho/social support from outside. Programs which train school psychologists to support schools after crises by the European School Psychology Centre for Training (ESPCT) have been shown to be effective. The techniques have been regularly updated through the sharing of experiences from different scenarios since 2002.

Crisis can be an opportunity

Lots of trauma reactions occur in armed conflicts. Some of the first strategies that were developed to help traumatised people resulted from wars.

Catastrophes make people think about what they can do to help, and how to prevent similar events from occurring in the future.

After the holocaust psychologists were interested in finding out why some

of the victims who survived could go on dealing with everyday life challenges while others could not. Research about resilience in Israel has found that people have distinct coping strategies and that everyone develops individual preferences about which strategy works best for them (Lahad et al, 2013).

People who develop useful strategies and use them effectively will be best at coping with stressful situations. For people who want to help it is important to activate the coping strategies in individuals, and groups of people, who have been affected by critical incidents. The Israeli Mooli Lahad found a system of coping categories called BASIC-Ph, which will be described later. It was developed in Northern Israel in the 1980's at that time when rockets from Lebanon were adversely affecting local people. Lahad's ideas were used by local school psychologists to help relieve the effects of trauma in schools.

Contribution from different countries

Another area of crisis response has been developed in the USA. After the Oklahoma bombing President Clinton asked the National American School Psychology Association (NASP) to develop guidelines for assisting schools after disasters. The bombing incident had revealed that schools were affected by the bombing because parents and children had been either killed or injured in the building. NASP joined with the National Emergency Assistance Team (NEAT) to look out for promising models. They found it in the guidelines and protocols for talks in the National Organization of Victim

Assistance (NOVA) which was used for psychological support after accidents. It is still the main model used in ESPCT courses. The method for talks with groups and individuals is called Group Coaching for Coping (GCC).

Using the research of Lahad and the USA studies, individuals such as Bill Pfohl in the USA (who was a member of the NEAT) took the initiative to run training courses on effective methods to deal with crisis response incidents in schools.

The history of ESPCT Training Courses

EU funding

Funding for the training courses for school psychologists in European states was available through the Comenius program, a program to fund courses for school staff. A Bavarian school psychologist, Bernhard Meissner organised the first European training course in 2003. This involved trainers from Germany, USA and Israel. These multinational training courses were successfully organized until 2014 when a new format Erasmus replaced Comenius. Unfortunately, the new funding format stopped the successful development of the international courses because it became too difficult for many colleagues to apply for funds. More than a thousand school psychologists had been educated by then.

Initiative of individuals

The initiative of individuals had resulted in the successful growth of this program. They understood that it would be useful for their countries to have a trained group of helpers for

schools. This way trainings came about in German states, in Great Britain, Cyprus, even Russia. Thanks to Poul Skaarup Jensen the first training in Denmark was organized in Jutland which was followed by more trainings in Denmark since then.

European and worldwide cooperation

Crisis Management in Schools (CMiS) is a product of cooperation among school psychologists and its vehicle for useful cooperation. In the International School Psychology Association (ISPA) knowledge was spread about what was going on in the world in this field. Firstly Bernie Stein from Israel held a keynote in 1996 in the ISPA conference in Eger, Hungary. Since the beginning of this century CMiS has been a constant topic in these worldwide meetings. For European school psychology it became the topic for most intense cooperation. Since 2009 ESPCT has organised meetings of representatives from many European countries who keep in contact about their experiences and sharing improving procedures. Through these meetings and in ISPA worldwide exchange is continuing.

The history of CMiS in Europe is an example how different influences like disasters, initiatives of politicians and professional individuals as well as a combination of lucky circumstances can result in opening and pushing a new and important field for school psychology and development of schools.

The following article describes the principles, strategies and the contents of training courses offered by the Euro-

pean School Psychology Centre for Training (ESPCT) which is affiliated to the International School Psychology Association (ISPA). Target groups are school psychologists who are best equipped with abilities useful for this task.

General principles

Why crisis management in schools by school psychologists?

In the 1970's medical professionals found the police and medics were needed in road traffic accident situations. In addition, a different type of support was needed for people who suffered from trauma, shock and disorientation in the accident. Jeffrey Mitchell developed Critical Incident Stress Management, which was to help intervention forces to cope with dreadful experiences they might have suffered. It consists of a list of questions to be gone through in groups. This was first used with mentally affected people of accidents, after it had proved to be helpful, to first aiders.

School as a system is affected

In road accidents people are involved who do not live together or work together (except a family who are together in a car, or a group from a firm). People who need psychological support may be together in small groups afterwards and the group may need support together. When a critical incident happens in a school, or to a group of a school, when being together in an event organized by the school, the school as a whole is involved. Some of the students or teachers may have been killed, or injured, or shocked.

Some of them will not be able to go on functioning at once like before for a shorter or longer time. That means the normal procedures of a school are interrupted for days, weeks or even months and years – as we see it happen in extreme events like shootings.

Different persons and groups need to be supported

This means firstly individuals gain from support about how to cope best with their stress experience in the event. School psychologists are used to counsel students and teachers.

Secondly, groups like classes or the school staff will profit from interventions preparing them on how to deal with the new situation destroying their usual routines. School psychologists do that very often in other circumstances, too.

Thirdly, school leadership will be faced with a number of new challenges. When can a class go on with their lessons and exams? What can be done when some teachers cannot go on with their job or at least are often unable to teach their classes? Unusual questions come up from parents or students and superiors. They are grateful to get support at least by having an independent expert who can listen and can recommend solutions. School psychologists in their daily work often support school leadership also.

Long-term support is offered best by an internal school support system

The fourth reason for teaching school psychologists to support schools is that

there may other response teams coming into the school to help. But sooner or later they will inevitably leave. Yet, we know that reactions to the event may come up strongly after several weeks or months. Then it is helpful when there is a support system that works continually for these schools, some of whom are specially trained for this job, and their colleagues who work with them when they intervene directly after the critical event. The latter remain there when their specialised colleagues leave and can take care for individuals who may need more long term support. The intervening system from outside the school will go on working hand in hand with their colleagues who oversee the school. The number of critical incidents observed by schools appears to have increased in recent years. This may be because of an increased awareness in school about the availability of outside help from specially trained school psychologists.

When a crisis event occurs it can cause strong and deep reactions in adults and children. There is a growing awareness and expectation for school staff to be ready to lead the response to crises in schools. When there are support teams they prepare school staff to do as much as they feel able to do on their own. The leaders of the schools and their staff usually do function well, but they are often overwhelmed by the event and they are grateful for assistance by trained Psychological First Aid responders. In many cases there are tasks left which they want better prepared helpers to take over.

Principles and strategies

ESPCT has developed over many years' principles, strategies and tools which will help to offer effective support. Following exposure to crisis events adults and children can display symptoms of acute distress (shock, crying, anger, confusion, fear, sadness, grief, and pessimism).

Psychological First Aid

In most cases these symptoms are temporary and gradually lessen in the days and weeks following the event. The way adults react to a crisis can have a significant effect on how further development of the support system in the schools will occur. Teachers, parents, and other caregivers inevitably play a critical role in helping children cope with crises. However, some children (and adults) may be at risk of more extreme reactions because of personal circumstances. The confidence, knowledge, and capability of school staff responding to such events provides support for their needs and reinforces their coping strengths. What is needed in the aftermath of a crisis is not therapy but psychological first aid, which involves giving information about the event, information about why we react the way we do, what can be done to be able to cope with the new situation and activating personal coping strategies.

Nearest and dearest are best emotional support

Families, and close friends of affected persons are usually the best people to provide support. Children need their parents to feel safe, adolescents need

their peers, and students listen to their teachers for advice. Experts from outside (incoming Crisis Response Team) may have more knowledge and experience in which way they help but they will offer their advice through parents and teachers if they feel able to offer it. They may coach them for being a good support.

Professionals do not take over but empower

From the start it is important that the outside professionals do not intend to take over the responsibilities of the school, but rather to support the school in its efforts to deal with the adverse effects of the tragedy. That means the school staff and leadership must continue to be responsible for doing the best that they can. They hand over only to outsiders what they cannot do, as they should not feel disempowered by medical support. They may be empowered by being coached e.g. how to talk to a class or how to deal with some especially vulnerable children. They are the ones who stay there when the supporters from outside leave and the more they know what they can do in special situations the better.

Support the school leadership

A school is a system of different groups and people who work together according to certain routines. This routine can be disrupted by a critical incident. Therefore, an important role of the incoming Crisis Response Team is to support school leadership and staff to help the school as a system to return to normality. When to open school for whom, how to deal with students who

need more time than others to be able to join normal lectures, how to talk to classes to help them activate their resources to get back to normal functioning. It is important to notice that schools as systems need help in crisis management not only individual support.

Refer to therapy

For some affected people it may be that even after several weeks or months the stress reactions that are impeding their daily life do not fade away, or their symptoms may be getting worse. Then these persons must be referred to trauma therapy.

Preparation is important

Critical incidents in schools are occasions to think about the future, too. They show what can be, and should be done either to prevent dreadful events or to be able to react in the best possible way. Catastrophes are an opportunity to improve safety in schools.

At the time of crisis there are many tasks to be carried out. This is another reason for asking those known to the affected persons to offer support. When knowledge and skills on how to do this has been taught before a crisis occurs people are better prepared. By identifying roles in advance (who will do what, when and how) the response to crisis is much more effective.

Helpers should know their own patterns of affection and reaction

It is important for school caregivers to explore their own experiences and feelings with regard to crisis response. They need to think about their own

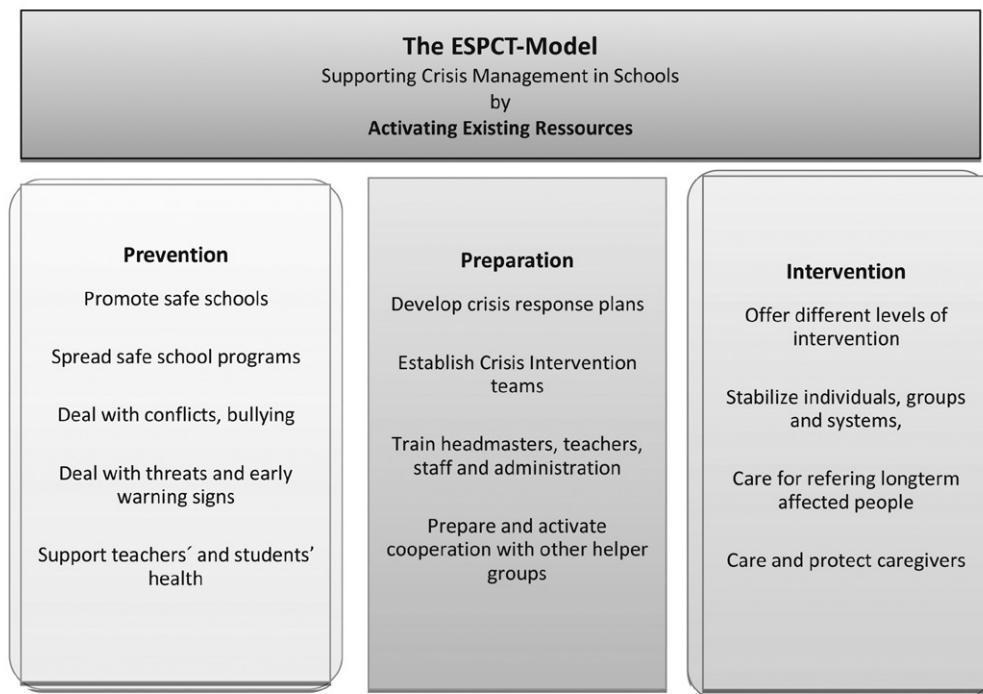
vulnerabilities and have knowledge about coping during and after the crisis, reactions (to death), and exposure to disaster. The key to managing a critical incident is to establish a crisis intervention team in a school, have a school crisis response plan, organize logistics and coordination. This team is supported by an incoming crisis intervention team of trained school psychologists to offer support to those individuals and groups who cannot get efficient support through local helpers because they are overwhelmed themselves or not trained sufficiently.

Phases Model of Crisis Intervention

It has proven efficient and helpful to differentiate several phases of crisis management in order to handle the great amount of aspects properly that have to be dealt with in a short time.

All three phases are merging into one another. Experience tells us that development of Crisis Management in Schools (CMiS) does not start with prevention. The usual sequence is starting with support after a large catastrophe hits a school and an effective intervention is offered which is reported to other schools. From this event conclusions are drawn for improving the intervention for individuals and for the school as a system. Far-sighted educators recognize the importance of the intervention for their schools and start to train groups for their schools, establishing psychological first aid teams in their schools. Frameworks must be developed for helpers in the school system within which they can function best.

The ESPCT Model consists of three phases:



This way they start **the preparation phase** in which support for future critical incidents is developed, preparing crisis response plans, establishing school crisis response teams, informing principals and school staff for such events and establish networks of helpers in their neighbourhood and region. Schools become aware of the fact that they can limit the psychological damage of tragedies for their students and teachers and maintain psychological health.

It becomes clear as well that part of the efforts should be to make **schools as safe as possible**. This is part of the prevention phase. Safe schools should take care to make school facilities as safe as possible through effective alarm systems, school drills for differ-

ent events etc. Safe school programs include support for different kinds of difficulties children might have, they include bullying prevention and intervention plans as well and conflict resolution. Dealing with threats is of great importance to prevent actual violent acts and to prevent suicides. Teachers' and students' mental health as the basis for good learning is observed and supported.

Crisis management in schools is an important contribution to school development. ESPCT courses were developed since 2002 and are still being developed further now in order to train school psychologists for the different tasks. **School psychologists have the best basic qualification** for being effective helpers in schools for indi-

viduals, groups, and school authorities. The short overview listed below describes the strategies, techniques, tools, and skills, which are taught in the courses.

The ESPCT model of crisis management in schools has been used since 2002 in different European countries. Experts in the field regularly exchange on their experiences, and new insights, and there is a lot of scientific evidence to back proceedings. Reinforcing personal coping skills is the main aim of Psychological First Aid, not therapy to which affected people are referred to when the first shock does not fade away. In critical incidents the usual routine is broken. Empathy for the victims is needed as well as clear knowledge what will help people. This means that the approach is more directive than usual in psychological help. A clear structure is used for dealing with the chaos and easy tools will lead helpers. To explain affected people what is going on with them as reaction to an unusual experience. Psychoeducation is a very effective means to lead people back to normality.

Basic principles for interventions

In World War I an important principle was followed to help injured and traumatized soldiers best: **proximity, immediacy, and expectancy**. They should be cared for near the place where they were with their colleagues, not transferred to an unknown, foreign place. For schools that means not leaving the school where a disaster happened when it is safe there again. The signs of a catastrophe can be removed possibly, e.g. bullet holes in the walls.

Meet where it happened

The event will never be forgotten. We need to believe in the possibility that we will go on to live despite what happened. The earlier we return to our normal life the better, without jumping too quickly over the experience we have had. So we may meet with students and teachers in their schools where dreadful things happened and do that step by step. We suggest that they support each other, and we work out together the best way that they can return to the school i.e. go hand in hand with friends/parents or other supportive adults, go slowly, use a special way, stop and talk about how they feel in between, let brave ones go ahead, use imagery, be aware of breathing regularly. Thus we create an atmosphere of positive expectancy. And this should happen as soon as possible. These principles guide our interventions.

First needs: safety, food, contact with nearest

When trained school psychologists are on the site within hours it is important that police can guarantee safety for them. Helpers then can help to meet first needs of victims which are psychologically affected: Then information is required, physical needs like food and drink must be met, social connections must be made according to the options we have. It is 36 – 48 hours after the event when the first shock is overcome that work with most of the involved population can begin. A systematic approach to activate resources, can be offered. It is the Group Coping for Coaching (GCC) protocol that ESPCT

trained psychologists use with groups and individuals.

Support for individuals and groups

Order the chaos!

The first step of the intervention is to order the chaos. There are lots of requirements and we try to find out two things: Who needs which support and who can offer it best. Some of the requirements may be met best by the natural social support system, family, friends, teachers, colleagues, classmates, peers and the local professional support systems in the school and in the community. To include local responders is important because they will go on supporting those in need when the external helper team has left.

Publish meeting places

People who look for support must know where they can meet supporters. Opportunities where to meet and talk are to be published through social media, phone and social channels. Sometimes the school is not accessible for some time when the police do their investigation. Then other suitable places must be found or portable containers have to be placed near the school.

Psychoeducation is helpful

Information for teachers, parents, students about stress reactions in such a situation is important to make them understand that their unusual reactions are natural, common after an unusual event. They are reassured that those reactions will gradually normalize depending on different factors:

event itself, the appraisal and coping styles, the psychological and biological responses to it, gender influence...

Coping, activate resources, plan activities

It will help to go through events they will have to face in the next hours and days and how they could deal with them. This will activate coping resources as well as reminding them of their usual coping channels and encourage them to use them deliberately. Activating these channels we have the multi modal coping system of Mooli Lahad in mind. It categorizes six coping channels: **belief**, **affect**, **social**, **imagination**, **cognition**, and **physical** (acronym BASIC-Ph). It is easily activated in groups when they are asked what helped them in the past when they had a really bad day. Different persons will mention different activities, which might give ideas to others. Some may decide to do activities together like just meeting or doing sports together. These plans will show people that they are not helpless. Their sense of self-efficacy is revived and the sense of collective efficacy as well, the feeling of collectiveness is improved which is calming and giving hope. These categories were defined by a group of researchers around Stevan E. Hobfoll 2007.

Since stronger stress reactions can occur not at once but after some time the development of reactions should be monitored for a longer period. Caring adults should be informed what they should watch out for. Meetings with most vulnerable groups and individuals should be offered as often as neces-

sary until they feel back to normal again.

Grief rituals are helpful as BASIC-Ph suggests as well. There are often people found who are specialized on this field like faith-based people. It is important to be aware of and care for cultural and religious differences among people of different background.

Special challenge: suicide

When students notice that their friends are depressed e.g. after losses or failures and separations they are alarmed. They usually are not able to help the one in risk properly beside be together with them and help them cheer up. Then they may ask a teacher of their trust what to do and then school psychologists will be contacted and should be prepared what to do. They may be the first to talk to the one in risk and his parents before they can refer the one to a specialist. School psychologists must be prepared for a situation when someone who survived committing suicide and comes back to his class. How can the class and the one returning be prepared in a proper way? A suicide is an occasion when we can talk to classes about this problem and what we can do to help kids to find help in order to prevent suicide. All these situations are different and need reflection and practice talks and thin about plans before they happen.

Talk about what helps to prevent suicide

Parents often do not want that a suicide of their child is known but they should be aware of the possible risk of not telling the truth. Since we cannot

prevent rumors and we do not want to lose credibility, we have to tell the truth as soon as possible.

Details of how someone ended his life should not be told in detail if not been published otherwise. Classmates must know that we do not know exactly why someone decided to end his life. For classmates of the deceased it is important to know that there is no situation in life when they cannot get help. They should contact adults they trust in and they should be informed where they can get professional support.

Do not glorify suicide

A suicide might bring about classmates or other students from the school to plan the same. Any kind of glorification of a suicide should therefore be avoided. This is especially difficult when the one who committed suicide was an admired and well known pupil. Parents often refrain from telling others the truth about a suicide of one of their children. School authorities must agree with them on what should be said and what not.

Special challenge: threats

As a reaction to an event when a school was attacked by a shooter or a bomb other schools – mainly nearby – are threatened by similar violence. Then they have to decide when to involve police in order to ensure safety. When safety is guaranteed by police it still is the task of the school to take care for a social atmosphere which reduces the danger of the use of violence. ESPCT uses a number of questions to find out how big the danger is and then to decide about measures how to talk about

this threat with teachers, classmates, peers, parents, school counselling and other agencies. For this purpose, all those among the school staff who know the perpetrator, or the one accused of being the perpetrator, have to take responsibility together.

Support for the school as a system

After a critical event the social fabric of the whole system is destabilized. Normal routines like daily lessons, dates for exams cannot go on as usual. To get back to routines it will take a shorter time for some classes, and longer for others, especially those who were more in the centre of the catastrophe. For groups is true what is true for individuals as well: they do not react the same way and should be allowed to return to normality at their appropriate pace. This is not easy to arrange when we have lots of people in groups of twenty to thirty who need the same time tables. Many flexible arrangements have to be made in order to meet as many requirements as possible. Planning of the school staff and the school leadership must go on much longer than usual and have in mind different aspects. For this procedure advice from experts from outside can give useful orientation.

Coaching for principals

Sometimes it is not easy for principals to accept advice from external helpers without feeling that they are losing independence and the feeling of being still competent for the job. Sensitive support will allow them to understand that in this situation when they are overloaded with requirements it will be

a sign of overview and competency to accept support helping them to deal with themselves as well as others.

There are their teachers, the victims, the parents of victims, the media, superiors, and perhaps politicians. To have someone independent with whom they can share issues and who may as well ask for their own wellbeing is really very important.

Trauma history of a school is important

Every school has a trauma history. It is important to know it because it can influence the reactions of individuals and the whole community to the present event. The same attention has to be given to the personal trauma history of individuals. Many teachers will face unusual situations with their students, sometimes with themselves or their colleagues, too. Coaching by professionals and supervision in groups or alone should be accessible for them.

Schools nearby may be affected

It is useful to think of schools around the school that was directly hit by the disaster. Like in an earthquake others near the centre are shocked as well. According to the circles of vulnerability this does not only mean physical proximity but as well social affinity e.g. through members of a family who are in the different schools. The influence can as well be brought about because another school had a similar event in the past and therefore many feel affected again through empathy. To think of them and find ways of addressing them will be accepted gratefully. Local agencies should be made

alert. There will be many people outside the school whom nobody knows personally who are affected because of special trauma history or sensitivity.

The media

Media reports can deepen trauma

The media are a special challenge. Many of them are not looking for the most accurate facts to report but for the most sensational pictures or information, sometimes just rumours told by a person interviewed. In critical events it is important to have the facts clear: what happened, what we know, why it happened. In the beginning when police investigations are starting often many facts are not clear. It may take days or even weeks to be sure who the perpetrators were, whether it was one or whether there were more than one. Rumours may make the public feel unsafe. This is not what we want to achieve. The aim of the helpers is to help people to return to the feeling of safety and hope for an acceptable future.

Media should be used to be helpful

On the other hand, media can be very helpful for achieving this aim. They can give secure information about facts, they can inform about reactions of traumatizing situations and how people can deal with them. They can inform when and where people can get support. Media are the best and easiest means to spread this important information.

Media should not have access to meeting with affected people

It is necessary to make sure that media representatives do not have access

to schools without controlling what they do there, who they talk to and who they take photos of. Teachers and student should be warned not to give interviews. When they are not well informed about everything and especially when they are emotionally aroused they may say things they will regret later. Especially students must know that they need not talk to journalists and they should be told how they can avoid that.

Requirements for helpers

Helpers should know what to do, that means to be competent. If they know then they can be confident and calm. An affected person unsure of the future wants someone to address them who knows what should be done and what the affected one needs. This is the basic requirement.

Leadership is important

The teams need leaders. When quick decisions have to be made leadership is indispensable. There often is no time for long discussions. It is helpful when the team members and their team leader have the same training and follow the same procedures and protocols.

Different roles in helper teams

Because there are different tasks it is useful that there are different roles assigned to the team members. The team leader has to take care of his team members, e.g. he must decide when one of his team is exhausted and should take a break. Team members should not work longer than 3 – 5 days without a break depending on how exhausting their interventions are and

how resilient they are. It is useful to have more helpers in the background who can come in when needed.

The team leader is in contact with other helper groups, the school authorities, and steering committees. It is useful to have someone responsible for logistics like food for the team, overnight facilities and other necessary things. Someone should be the media contact person if that job is not taken by an official spokesperson by the education system. It is important to have someone who takes notes and takes care of the documentation.

Helpers work in pairs

One of the basic rules for interventions is that helpers only work in pairs. It is for their own safety and to make their job successful. If the one in lead of a talk finds he is too emotional to continue, or taken by surprise, and does not know how to react, the other one can take over. The other advantage is that they can exchange their impressions of the intervention they just went through. Thus, crisis interventions are a unique opportunity to grow by sharing experience and to improve one's expertise.

Supervision should be provided

The team and perhaps the team leader should make sure that they can get supervision after an intervention as a team or individually. Part of preparation of helpers is to allow helpers to look back in their own trauma history and to think about how they coped with past events. And they should be aware of their own motives for offering help because this may influence their ways of supporting and its efficacy. If,

for example, they are still in grief about a loss they had recently, this could worsen the situation for others.

Structural requirements

The planning team should have a room for themselves in which they can store personal documents, reports of talks and other decisions. Plans for the relevant day should be shown on a board so that every team member can get orientation during the day.

The team will meet in the beginning of the day and at the end to make their plans for the day and in the evening for the next day together with local helpers.

Inter-vention

There will be an inter-vention phase as long as a team or several teams from outside the school offer their support. It will finish when the school is able to return to relatively ordinary routines. This phase will finish with evaluation of the work that has been done by outside and local helpers and thanks to all who did their best.

There may be drawn conclusions for how the school will proceed, what has been learned for future similar events. In this phase – which we call post-vention phase – necessary support is still offered for some, referrals may be necessary to therapy.

Post-vention

The post-vention phase emerges without a definite border into the pre-vention phase. In this phase the school puts plans into action to make the school safer and prevent violence. For this purpose physical preparations are

put into action like improve the alarm system, prepare safety for different scenarios, e.g. lock into rooms or evacuate the school. A school safety team may take care of the social safety. Every child should know where and from whom they can get support concerning their academic achievement and personal wellbeing. Among programs for emotional social learning a no-bullying program is of utmost importance.

Conclusions from the event should be drawn on several levels of the school community, among different age groups, among parents, and school staff. Insights should be spread to other schools and among the school administration.

Preparation on all levels is prevention and we know that prevention is cheaper than intervention. A catastrophe can this way be a chance for a better and safer future.

Pre-vention and preparation

New ideas on how to prepare for future crises tend to occur in the intervention phase, and these ideas can be developed in the post-vention and mainly in the pre-vention phase. Beside the general aspects mentioned before the following are to be focussed on.

The better school psychologists are prepared for offering support in different scenarios the better they can assist schools. To prepare schools to be aware about how they can help themselves will lessen the burden for trained helpers in case of an incident. Even when schools are well prepared, it will be helpful for them to accept help from outside, particularly in case of a bigger

tragedy, because school staff can be affected deeply themselves.

Preparation for different scenarios

When a shooter is in the building the best form of protection is a 'lock-in'. In these cases it is important for those on the ground floor to be protected against shooting from outside through windows. Classes should be prepared by teachers how they can best lock themselves in. At least their teachers should know what to do. In other cases e.g. fire or a bomb the school has to be evacuated at once. Teachers and students should know the routines in each case and exercise in simulated drills. We do not recommend simulations of violent acts together with students but teachers should train what to do. It could be useful that parents know about them, too. School staff should know where best protected places are in school and how classrooms can be made as safe as possible.

Alarms and meeting places

Meeting places should be carefully chosen by school administration and school crisis teams. All teachers and school personnel must know them. Plans should be posted in classrooms. Different places are needed for parents to meet and for students. Parents should meet where they do not block access to schools for helpers with their cars.

Alarm signals must be clear. All school personnel must know what alarm signals mean. Communication connections between class rooms and central office is recommended.

Police can act easier in certain cases when they have an actual plan of the rooms of the school which could be at the police station in charge of the school.

School crisis response teams and plans

School crisis teams are recommended. Though it can be helpful to have external teams helping the school. Help can be offered more effectively if the school is prepared on their own. In large scale events help from outside is compulsory and other cases the school decides when they want external help. For long term support it is useful to have helpers from the school working hand in hand with the incoming helper team in order to make transition for external to internal support smoother.

Drills for preparation

The better students know how they can protect themselves or avoid danger the better it will be for them. Doing drills of a shooting could on the other hand frighten children too much. It is recommended to discuss options with their teachers, involve parents and cooperate in preparing the children to the possible difficulties that might arise during and after the drill. Some drills can be executed by teachers and school personnel. Important issues can afterwards be talked about with students. It is equally important to prepare the students for the drill, so that it won't come as alarming surprise.

No bullying

Bullying is one of the main reasons for children and youths to feel bad at

school. Prevention and intervention are needed. There should be a program on how to stop bullying by interventions, there should be information about bullying and how dangerous for social health and personal wellbeing it is. There should be different intervention methods in order to be at hand when needed.

Conflict resolution

Conflict resolution for dealing with conflicts among school staff and between parents and teachers is a precondition for dealing effectively with situation which may otherwise poison the atmosphere of a school. This happens when they are not dealt with early enough because related persons do not know how to deal with them in an acceptable way. The better a school functions socially in an atmosphere of respect and mutual support the safer the community will feel and the safer they will be.

ESPCT

The European School Psychology Centre for Training (ESPCT) provides courses, workshops and presentations which are carefully chosen to meet high quality standards on these issues. The model started to be developed in 2002 by Bernhard Meissner- Germany, Prof. Bill Pfohl- U.S., Arthur Englbrecht (+ 2007), Dr. Yehuda Shacham & Dr. Shulamit Niv – Israel. Over the years of experience with training school psychologists several principles and strategies how to train effectively for different scenarios have been developed. They are as important as the principles and strategies for interven-

tions in order to prepare helpers for their job.

The first principle for helpers

It is important for all those who respond to be competent, confident, and calm. In order to achieve this aim ESPCT provides courses with practical step-by-step guidelines for school psychologists (teachers and principals) on how to respond when the tragedy occurs. Research has proved that to know what to do in a critical situation will help people react in the appropriate way. Besides knowledge, practical training is of great importance. This can be done by going to different scenarios of critical incidents in role plays which are evaluated afterwards. Our courses are as follows:

The Basic Course (intervention)

– 5 days

Theoretical background is given and discussed

School psychologists from all over Europe are invited to exchange their experience in crisis management and develop it further. Short term assistance is discussed including all necessary basic strategies and tools, care for the caregiver and how to collaborate with other helpers. Theory, simulations and exercises are interwoven during the course.

Participants prepare for dealing with their emotions in interventions

Participants are confronted with their own often deep and sometimes confusing emotions in critical situations. To be aware of them in advance and pre-

pare for how to deal with them is essential for ESPCT courses. What you need to prepare for as a helper is to know your own reactions to a stressful situation like that and to know about those of your partner helpers.

Share reflection insights and get to know different reactions

You can get information about what to do but you will get insight about helpers' competences only by reflection and feedback. Finally, participants implement their knowledge and expertise and establish special school crisis response teams in their schools at home. Emphasis lies on the fact that the interventions are not therapy but activation of resources in individuals, groups and the system school.

Simple tools are practiced

Another focus lies on the fact that simple tools are used and trained. In the beginning of an intervention not all facts we should know in order to plan the intervention properly are known. The tools to order chaotic situations must be simple because the situations we are facing are complex.

Simulations allow practice in advance

Simulating central scenarios which occur allow participants experience their own reactions as helpers and those of others: teachers, principals, students, parents, stakeholders, more or less affected people, politicians, journalists etc. They can give each other feedback on how they could deal with the relevant situations differently and effectively.

Balance heavy theme with relaxation and warming periods

It is important to balance memories of loss and deaths in the lives of participants of which they definitely are reminded now and then with periods of good humour and relaxation. Warming-up exercises are mixed in between the sessions, breaks are kept clearly to allow participants to think of other things. And sometimes there is laughter. All are encouraged to take care of themselves in order to keep in good mood.

Thus ESPCT courses address head, heart, and hand as Pestalozzi defined effective learning. This kind of support is a vital step to enable schools to care and promote the psychological health of children and staff.

Aims of the course are: exchange of experiences in crisis management in schools, learn about coping strategies and personal channels (BASIC Ph), deal with death and bereavement, start crisis intervention: main questions, roles, circles of vulnerability and support, inform about trauma, trauma reactions, and dealing with trauma, learn how to use practically Group Coaching for Coping (GCC), deal with the media, care for themselves as caregivers.

The Advanced Course

(prevention/intervention) – 5 days

The recent developments show that violence in schools is growing in a way that was not known before 2000 in Europe: shootings followed by threats. While this is a new development suicides frequently happened and still

happen among older kids and adolescents. They are confronting schools with sudden unexpected deaths and lead to shock reactions among individuals, and classes in the whole school like when other catastrophes occur.

People are affected by suicide in different ways and need different kinds of support

Interventions similar to the basic course are needed but other aspects are to be taken care of as well. E.g. it is necessary to care for preventing imitation of suicide. It is necessary to be prepared for a situations when class mates and teachers are concerned about a student at risk. Parents of a student at risk are to be talked to and the student himself. A meeting with a class after suicide and after an attempted suicide has to be prepared and practiced. We need to foresee reluctant principals and parents to allow talking to classes openly how to prevent suicide. The GCC trained in the basic course is adopted to these different situations, demonstrated and practiced.

How to deal with threats against schools

Threats are another special topic to deal with. When we deal with suicide and with threats danger is not over but still imminent. Understanding that students who plan a violent act against their classmates or teachers or their school in general develop their plan over a long time. To understand this development is crucial for preventing the final act. It is as essential to prepare for understanding this development and to draw the right conclusions

how to prevent violence together with those who know the threatener. In a simulation of such a meeting the participants will practice what has to be done. Schools understand more and more that professional support is needed in these cases or at least that it is very useful and ask for it.

Aims of the course: exchange of experiences, pacing and leading of those at risk, dealing with suicide situations, suicide attempts, support teachers and classmates who fear that someone is suicidal, Group Coaching for Coping special for dealing with situations connected with suicide, avoid imitation, safety conferences dealing with threats and threatening students, Safe Schools, developing and maintaining crisis intervention networks

The Advanced Course coordination and trauma counselling (preparation) – 5 days
Beside organizational management methods, which are needed to structure large numbers of helpers, as well as addressing the immediate needs of vulnerable persons, those who need individual or group trauma therapy must be identified and referred to therapy. It is necessary to support all teachers, families, and school leadership in special and helpful ways. This course coordination focuses on these extraordinary issues. A core part will be how to support people affected with Acute Stress Disorder, before PTSD manifests itself. Trauma counselling will be a discussed topic. Another main focus lies on the fact that psychologists – and school psychologists – usually are not

trained for leadership. But in CMiS leadership is significantly important.

Aims of the course: Freshen-up intervention and coping tools from the basic course, large scale critical incidents: organizational aspects, long-term support and how to identify needs for referral to trauma therapy, trauma counselling according to behaviour theory, SeeFar CBT - trauma counselling with a mixture of different partly creative methods, Safe Schools, train school personnel for crises, violence prevention, problem solving, conflict resolution, mediation, peace education, life skills, developing and maintaining crisis intervention networks

The three courses mentioned above are mainly targeting school psychologists. Another target group are principals who can be trained for their special tasks in separate courses of one or rather two days.

The Prevention Course (prevention) – 5 days

This course teaches the basic theories and the main practical tools for handling conflicts in schools among staff and students. Conflict management theories and practical approaches are presented. Dealing with bullying among students according to the “Shared Concern method” therefore is one training part. The promotion of safe school approaches will be presented with practical examples and the implementation of it in the schools and/or regions of the participants will be planned. The target groups are all kinds of school personnel: teachers,

headmasters, counsellors and school psychologists.

Aims of the course: get an overview about strategies and programs of prevention in schools, building structures and processes to make schools a safe place for students and staff, training in two different models of prevention: deal with bullying (use a non-punitive approach like Shared Concern method) and conflict management in school staff

Organization of the courses

There are courses organized by ESPCT open for school psychologists as mentioned above, some are open for other school personnel, or are rather specially designed for special target groups, e.g. SCM can be addressed to teachers. Participation can be funded by ERASMUS for countries of the European Union. Interested school psychological centers or schools must apply for them at their national ERASUMS centers.

Another possibility is that they are organized by educational authorities or school psychology associations for their country or region, ESPCT sends their trainers to conduct the course.

Participants

Over the last fifteen years about 2300 school psychologists from almost all European countries were trained. They were asked for support in many different critical incidents which affected schools. What they learned was that it is more helpful to coach related persons of the affected ones than to do the job themselves. In some cases when related people, teachers, parents, friends

are too much affected themselves external help may be asked for. Almost all participants reported that knowledge and understanding of the whole process also helped them in their daily work and in their personal development.

Trainers and trainees: on-going exchange
ESPCT international trainers conduct courses with international participation, national trainers conduct courses in their country. They keep in touch about their experiences and develop courses further according to them.

All the former trainees are in the ESPCT data base and are informed about developments. Representatives of trained groups in European countries and contact persons for CMiS in their country met annually between 2009 and 2014. Together with the trainers they are members of Crisis Management in Schools (CMiS) – Interest group. They might offer assistance in international training efforts and support in major tragic events at schools all over the world. On-going exchange monitoring the development of crisis management in schools is a vital part of this new field of school psychological expertise. In 2017 there was a meeting in Mainz together with researchers in the field of CMiS in order to actualize ESPCT principles and strategies.

The group of trainers was increased following training at a course in Frankfurt in January 218. The ESPCT – trainers are also preparing for situations in which acts of violence or threats are conducted by refugees or youths with migrant background.

Conclusion

Preparing Schools for well planned interventions in cases of disasters, violence and deaths based on sound principles has become a central task for school psychologist in many countries in the world. Knowledge and training in Crisis Management in Schools is necessary in every school and therefore further efforts will be carried out to improve the preparation for events that nobody wants to happen, but that occur.

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